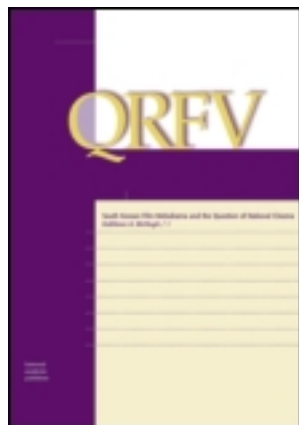


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London à la mod: Fashion, Genre, and Historical Space in *Performance*

MATTIAS FREY

Since the success of the continuing *Austin Powers* franchise in the late 90s, the notion of 1960s “Swinging London” has been a familiar trope. And in fact, a number of films from 1964–1968 consciously reflected and invented the notions of youth, freedom, and uninhibited sexuality associated with “Swinging London.” What strikes one upon reading both journalistic and academic writings on these films, however, is the great extent to which fashion symptomatically dictates and organizes the discourse on these films. One essay that wants to see Michelangelo Antonioni’s *Blow-Up* (1966) as an allegory of the Cold War, for instance, begins in sartorial fragments: “White straight leg jeans worn rolled over black half boots. Crochet dress. Red ankle strap shoes. Jeff Beck at the Guitar” (Williams, 245). This approach is a quasi-subconscious indicator of how vital fashion is in understanding how these films function. Elsewhere, Peter Wollen speculates that the best book on this era and these films might be one on clothes (Wollen, 20). In this spirit I would like to test the idea bubbling just below the surface here and try to understand one of these films, Donald Cammell and Nicholas Roeg’s *Performance* (1970), in “fashionable” terms. This study will be much less an inventory of outfits and much more a textural analysis exploring (1) how using “fashion” as a unifying concept helps us resolve *Performance*’s contested structural and generic status and (2) how the film maps “Swinging London,” retreats into interior designs, and itself has been fashioned over time into historical and mnemonic fabrics.

Performance begins with a dizzying and disorientating flurry of intercutting from one unknown place to another: from the naked bodies of a couple having kinky sex to a car on an English country road. Sexual business completed, the man, Chas Devlin (James Fox), hurries his partner Dana out of his flat. The first half of the film unfolds as a gangster film following Chas, who is a hatchet man for his gay crime boss, Harry Flowers. Chas’ work becomes increasingly violent: in order to scare a lawyer intent on naming Flowers as the boss behind a series of crimes, Chas and his gang ambush the lawyer’s car, destroying the Rolls Royce with acid and leaving the chauffeur tied to the ruins of the car, having shaved his head. After another action in which Chas actually kills a target he wasn’t supposed to, Chas finds himself in mortal danger, both from the police and from Flowers, who makes it clear that the “firm” will kill Chas if they can find him.

Desperate for a place to hide Chas sets out for an aunt in Barnstaple. At the train station, however, he overhears a black musician, Noel, telling his mother that he has just left his room in Powis Square, owing back rent. Sensing an opportunity, Chas turns up

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at the house claiming to be a juggler friend of Noel's and offering to pay the back rent. Chas is eventually accepted as a lodger by the house's residents: Turner, a reclusive former rock star played by Mick Jagger, and his two girlfriends, Pherber (Anita Pallenberg) and Lucy (Michelle Breton). The second half of the film chronicles Chas' attempt to organize an escape to America via telephone calls to his cousin Tony while Turner and Pherber explore Chas' psyche, feeding him hallucinogenic mushrooms and playing increasingly complicated sexual and psychic games with him.

During the trip they dress Chas up in various wigs, costumes, and make-up with the pretext of disguising him for a passport photo, causing Chas to question fundamentally his sexual identity and his thug life and image. In the final scene, Flowers' henchmen finally catch up with Chas and he asks to be allowed to say goodbye to Turner. Chas enters the rock star's bedroom, draws his pistol and shoots Turner through the head. The camera follows the bullet through Turner's head out through the roof of the house and follows Chas from behind as he is escorted towards the white Rolls Royce in which Harry Flowers is waiting. As the Rolls draws away, it is Turner's face that looks out the window.

This summary points to the troubles that critics have always had with *Performance*'s basic shape. It is a gangster film that dissolves into a hippie psychodrama and writers on *Performance* have complained that it seems as if two quite disparate films are somehow slapped together as one. I want to argue that the structural and generic peculiarities that have confounded critics might be profitably understood with a reading of the film that offers "fashion" as its central metaphor; the sartorial metaphors of "dressing-up" and "trying-on" provide us with a unifying conceit for the two parts and genres at work in the film. *Performance* is, I submit, above all a "makeover" movie in both halves, a film about trying on different identities.

Stella Bruzzi's comments on fashion in the gangster film are useful in understanding how we might begin to address *Performance* as a makeover movie. In her book *Undressing Cinema*, Bruzzi argues that what governs the iconography of the gangster genre is a "constant, ultimately futile striving for a stereotyped, idealized, and unattainable image of masculinity . . . The myth of the gangster is proclaimed and codified by the way he dresses, the suit, hat, accessories, and trench coat being the most common identifying marks of his status" (Bruzzi, xviii and 71).

In addition, Bruzzi ascribes a homoerotic undercurrent to the genre, on account of its characters' over-identification with appearance and open display of fetishistic interest in each other's clothes (Bruzzi, 75). By anyone's account including Bruzzi's, however, this homoeroticism is always repressed in traditional examples of the genre or sublimated in a minor character with questionable sexual tendencies, e.g., the character Rico's latent homosexuality in Mervyn LeRoy's *Little Caesar* (1931). What makes *Performance* so interesting, then, is the way in which it explicitly depicts a gay band of gangsters, thereby externalizing—or turning "inside out"—the tendency Stella Bruzzi has identified in the traditional gangster genre's subtext.

Although the first half of the film is ordinarily identified as the more staid, generic gangster picture, in fact it overflows with signs of the identity play to come. The film foregrounds Chas' attention to appearance and narcissism already in the opening sequence, where he watches his reflection while having sex, adjusting the mirror to get a better view; immediately afterwards and in fact throughout the first half Chas repeatedly returns to the bathroom mirror to "check himself out." So too are other figures in the criminal underworld preoccupied with fashion. Harry Flowers chastises Chas because he is "out of date." The gang performs revenge on a lawyer seen wearing outrageously stylized traditional English barrister's wigs and hats.

In one scene Harry Flowers emerges from the glittering curtains of a stage with his cronies in tow like a bizarre catwalk; the performance's "fashionable" signification is reinforced by the subsequent pan to a model (or mannequin?) "playing" the audience, the flashes of the fashion photographer's camera thereafter, and the headshots of Hollywood actors behind Flowers. The visual pun is naturally apt: after all, these gangsters do nothing but posture and put on airs—they play "dress-up" in the criminal underworld. Finally, the punishment that Chas dishes out to his victims—shaving their heads—also falls into this "dressing-up" category, above all because of the symbolic function of hair in the second half of the film; Chas later applies a series of dyes and wigs to himself in order to prevent Flowers and the others from recognizing him.

Indeed, like Quentin Tarantino's *Reservoir Dogs* (1992), another film that both quotes and subverts the gangster genre, *Performance* is a film about disguise and about sustaining a disguise. And if, as Eugene Rosow claims, the traditional gangster genre is based on "sartorial progression from dark and wrinkled nondescript clothing to flashy, double-breasted, custom-tailored striped suits with silk ties and suitable jewelry," (Rosow, 185) then *Performance* is an overdetermined example. Chas' sartorial progression moves far beyond striped suits into a thoroughly androgynous zone. His transformation into a Turner-esque dandy is at first a masquerade motivated by survival, but by the end of the film it becomes clear that Chas has indeed accepted the more fluid notion of sexuality and fashion to which Turner, Pherber and Lucy have introduced him.

Also important here in my discussion of how the halves of the film are indeed structurally compatible when seen through fashion is the surfeit of violence at work, especially in the film's first half. Violence, as we know both from the cinema of Quentin Tarantino as well as from the works of his critic Michael Haneke or Gaspar Noé, can itself become an aesthetic, prop, or dramaturgy—in a word, a fashion (Haneke, 93–98). Violence in *Performance* is depicted in such an over-the-top, stylized manner that it becomes abstraction. One scene is particularly exemplary. Preceding an ambush, the walls of Chas' flat are splashed and smeared with red paint in the manner of Jackson Pollock paintings.

This is emphasized in the editorial montage, which juxtaposes the "violent" paint-splashing with Turner's "interior decorating" of his walls and then Chas' overrun and feather-filled flat with the cluttered and semiotically overloaded mise-en-scène of Turner's room. Chas' attackers even inflect a sexual-semantic meaning onto this "performance"—they write "poof" with the paint on the wall. Moreover, as the scene continues, it becomes impossible to distinguish between the red paint on the walls and the blood, an association clearly signaled in the rapid cutting between the bloodied men fighting and the paint-stained walls. At the end of the scene, the connection between violence and fashion becomes all but explicit; the violent sequence actually dissolves into a quasi fashion shoot. As Chas' tormentors homoerotically attempt to make him "say" that he is gay, Roeg's camera intercuts fashion photos of Chas boxing, the rhythmic editing and the sound of the whip echoing the sound of a fashion photographer's camera.

The two "disparate" halves of *Performance* are thus reconcilable when we view the film through the lens of a fashionable discourse. *Performance* clearly takes the gangster genre as a source for quotation and viewer expectations. But if, as Stella Bruzzi maintains, the traditional gangster film ultimately "is about the man's acquisition of attributes that prove his masculinity and differentiation from the feminine" (Bruzzi, 93), *Performance* does exactly the opposite. Rather than inscribing sexual difference it deconstructs sexuality as a fluid spectrum as easily malleable as changing one's hat, clothes, or wig: with each moment comes the possibility of "dress-up" and "makeover."

The posters and other marketing materials released to accompany the film—the very paratextual elements that attempt to shape generic reception—betray the centrality of sartorial “makeover” to the film. This promotional poster portrays Mick Jagger practicing a transvestite makeover. As Marjorie Garber theorizes in *Vested Interests*, cross-dressing “is a space of possibility structuring and confounding culture” that not only challenges the male/female binary, but functions as an index of a general “category crisis,” calling into question whole sets of “identities previously conceived as stable, unchallengeable, grounded, and ‘known’” (Garber, 17, 13). The poster actualizes Garber’s expanded notion of transvestitism as deconstructive force quite literally in its linguistic play: it sets up a series of binaries (“madness”/“sanity”, etc.) only to end on a pun (“Vice. And Versa.”) that subverts the signifying system. This “space of possibility”—and the sartorial metaphor that informs it—is ultimately the key to understanding *Performance*’s generic status.

The schizoid structural and generic quality of *Performance* that I’ve attempted to reconcile up to now reflects a geo-historically locatable phenomenon. Although *Performance* is not necessarily “based on a real story,” its basic situation—the coexistence and social intermingling of the criminal underworld and bohemian pop stars—was a fact of life in 1960s London. The Harry Flowers gang in the film is based on a very famous gay gang of mobsters, the Kray brothers. Ronnie and Reggie Kray, twins from Hoxton in the East End, had moved to Chelsea in the early 60s and were actually part of the Chelsea set: they were ruthless “criminal stars” who hung out with the rock bands (including the Rolling Stones), dandies, mods, and the other beautiful people and their hangers-on. David Bailey, the London fashion photographer on whom the David Hemmings character in *Blow-Up* (1966) is based, photographed the Kray brothers for photo-records of the fashionable world at that time (Wollen, 22). At that time, in this city, such commingling was possible.

David Gilbert has described how cities, in addition to being the physical context for fashion, can themselves be fashion objects, subject to fashion cycles, and visual accessories in fashion’s iconography (Gilbert, 8). As Gilbert points out, “One of the established tropes of the international media is the identification and celebration of *the* dynamic, defining center of contemporary fashion culture” (Gilbert, 19). And indeed the late 1950s Rome of Federico Fellini’s *La Dolce Vita* (1960) or early 90s Seattle certainly seemed to be the epicenters of a certain zeitgeist. Mid 60s “Swinging London” is, however, the exemplar of this phenomenon if only because the clamor surrounding it was amplified exponentially by the ideology behind it: the aims were utopian, namely the radical change of social structures as they had hitherto been experienced (a permanent “makeover” of society), and success seemed inevitable.

And just as Georg Simmel theorizes that sartorial fashions trickle down from the vanguard to the masses (Simmel, 299), so too do fashionable cities and representations thereof gradually become products of mass appeal. It comes as little surprise then that in the mid-60s there was a concerted effort by American studios to make films that captured the new youth culture and its capital, London. Although rigorously formulated they cannot be said to constitute a genre, they were most certainly developed by industry insiders and recognized by audiences as films in which “London” is the star, the object of fashion. The theatrical trailer for *Blow-Up* is exemplary. Carlo Ponti and MGM, although certainly advertising *Blow-Up* as an auteurist Antonioni picture featuring the likes of Vanessa Redgrave and Sarah Miles, promise the viewer “eyewitness” access to another attraction: “the dazzle and madness of London today!” MGM’s press releases apparently go even further, describing London as where “teenage pop singing groups have their records sold by people their own age, and photographers who have barely started showing drive Rolls Royces with radio-telephones” (Lev, 135).

Film producers' fashion for "Swinging London" films led to a number of unmemorable throwaways like Robert Parrish's *Duffy* (1968) but did thankfully yield Richard Lester's *A Hard Day's Night* (1964), Roman Polanski's *Repulsion* (1965), as well as *Blow-Up*. These last three are all London films made by foreigners. The first and last great "Swinging London" film made by Britons would be *Performance*, shot in the summer and autumn of 1968 and, after much delay by Warner Brothers, finally released in 1970. And as one might expect, the London that Cammell and Roeg imagine is hardly a tourist's cartography and certainly not the blithe celebration of "Swinging London" that Warner Brothers had in mind. If *Performance* is a "dress-up" film which "makes-over" the gangster genre, then it also "makes-over" London and the "Swinging London" film. For the remainder of this essay I will examine how *Performance* fashions city space and retreats into interior designs, concluding with how it itself has been fashioned into fabrics of national cinematic and collective memory.

In its spatial structure, *Performance* closes and folds in on itself; its form is fundamentally centripetal. In the first half of the film we are privy to an array of locations marking a seedy topography of late 60s gangster London: Chas' pre-fab apartment, a courtroom, a sleazy nightclub, the waiting room of Paddington train station. Still, a number of the scenes are filmed outdoors: the action wanders throughout London and its various districts and shots of prominent landmarks like Trafalgar Square are occasionally included, although often we recognize these points of orientation only through car windows and other mediators. These outside sequences are hardly establishing shots in the strict sense. When Chas is forced to go on the run he turns up in Turner's turf north of the park to Powis Square, just off Portobello Road, then seen as a crumbling crime-ridden ghetto: already this marks a distinct geographical departure from predecessor "Swinging London" films like *The Servant*, *Repulsion*, and *Blow-Up*, which are all set in Chelsea or South Kensington.

And, unlike *Blow-Up*, in which the fashion-photographer wanders the city until the end, Chas' arrival at Turner's abode marks a permanent move into the interior: both spatially, in terms of Turner's nearly windowless, hermetically sealed flat, and well as emotionally, in the film's explorations of Chas' mind and body. This principal is quite literally born out in the final sequence, in which the camera follows a bullet penetrating Turner/Chas' head into his brain. Roeg's cinematography thus writes a map of the mind with an intimate architecture, a parallel born out both in the mise-en-scène as well as the editing.

As *Performance* moves into more intimate zones of Turner's flat and Chas' person, Roeg increasingly employs a dramatic, stylized lighting of reds, greens, and purples that one knows from Luchino Visconti's contemporaneous film *The Damned* (1969) or Rainer Werner Fassbinder's later *Lola* (1981). The montage, a veritable flutter of Burroughsian cut-up editing in the opening scenes, slows down somewhat to an irregular syncopation as Turner and Pherber play with Chas' sense of identity. In one ménage à trois sequence, Roeg discards 35mm altogether and shoots his grainy images beneath the sheets with a Super 8mm camera. The outside world is forgotten altogether as Roeg drafts the contours of an interior atlas of passion.

The intimate geography I am trying to map here is personified in the figure of Christopher Gibbs, the set designer for Turner's flat in *Performance* as well as other contemporary films (for example, *Blow-Up*, albeit uncredited). By profession Gibbs was an antiques dealer and interior decorator and was the choice for the movers and shakers in 1960s London (perhaps most significantly Gibbs designed Brian Jones' flat on Courtfield Road). Described as "a Wildean aesthete come to life" (Faithfull, 59), Gibbs was also the central figure in the Chelsea set, the man who introduced the gangster faction to the pop stars and linked the intellectuals to the junkies.

Gibbs' professed logic in his set design of *Performance* is vital for my discussion of the interior spaces of cities and minds: hallucinogenic drugs. Like many during the period, Gibbs believed in the "transforming quality of hallucinogenics on the collective conscious" (Savage 1995, 25). This—a logic based on the free association that magic mushrooms and LSD induce—was ultimately the (dis)organizing principle behind Gibbs' set design and Cammell and Roeg's montage. In "Swinging London" hallucinogens were seriously considered to be an interior design of the mind, a method for fashioning an open and liberated consciousness and were of course themselves a fashion.

Moreover, the desired effects of LSD and the Chelsea set's philosophy towards it—namely, a method of scrambling one's senses into seeing music, feeling light, or tasting words—begin to resemble Laura Marks' notion of the "haptic eye," which she uses to argue that cinema can appeal to senses that it cannot technically represent (such as smell and above all touch) and that these senses have a privileged relationship to memory (Marks, 129). Whether one subscribes to the Chelsea set drug manifesto or Laura Marks' scholarly version of the "haptic eye," it is certainly present in the cinema of *Performance*, as I have sketched in the examples above. Furthermore, Marks' later development of the phenomenological implications of tactile visuality links this discussion to my generic idea of "dressing-up" and "trying-on" identities from the first section, a "space of possibility" where simple binaries are confounded:

What is erotic about haptic visuality, then, may be described as the . . . loss of self, in the presence of the other . . . The giving-over to the other that characterizes haptic visuality is an elastic, dynamic movement, not the rigid all-or-nothing switch between an illusion of self-sufficiency and a realization of absolute lack. (Marks 193)

Performance reflects an interior design and was indeed an intimate design. The constellation of figures involved in the production were all friends, none (save James Fox and Nicholas Roeg) had any experience making movies, and Jagger, Pallenberg, and Breton were essentially playing themselves. It was, in effect, the first Warner Brothers "home movie." This intimate microgeography of the film's production corresponded, on a national-historical level, with the film's reception. In the US the film garnered terrible reviews like Richard Schickel's in *Time*: "the most disgusting and completely worthless film I have seen since I began reviewing" (Schickel, 61) or John Simon's *New York Times* piece: "an indescribably sleazy, self-indulgent, and meretricious film" (Simon). In Britain, however, the press received it with great sympathy. *Sight and Sound* and the then-fledgling *Time Out* embraced the film. Retrospectively, the film has only increased in importance in Britain, and namely vis-à-vis a complex system of national discourse.

Just as *Performance* is a result of an historical situation that had London catapulted to a fashion object, the film itself has enjoyed the status of a fashion object. In terms of British national cinema, *Performance* has been continuously re-cycled and credited as an influence for a whole host of films: for instance, Stanley Kubrick's violent aesthetic in *A Clockwork Orange* (1971), and numerous subsequent Cockney gangster films (such as Mike Hodges' *Get Carter* [1971] and Guy Ritchie's *Lock, Stock, and Two Smoking Barrels* [1998] and *Snatch* [2000]). Peter Wollen notes that Peter Greenaway's *The Cook, The Thief, His Wife, and Her Lover* (1989) borrows the ceremonial torture of a gang victim on the front of a luxury car, the androgynous child, and the fatal encounter between gangster and effete book-reader (Wollen, 23).

But beyond pure film history, *Performance* is a veritable palimpsest of memory and affect in the political struggle for control over the history space of "Swinging London." Just as films don't exist in historical vacuums, neither does a zeitgeist city like "Swinging London" and its representations. *Performance* regularly tops reader and critic polls in

British film journals like *Time Out* and *Sight and Sound* and has served a pivotal role in Britain's reckoning with the 1960s national mythologies, figuring alternately in Thatcherite and 68ers coming to terms with the past. In a series of memoirs and articles published over the last 10 to 15 years, *Performance* has come to represent the master narrative for "Swinging London" in the British popular consciousness.

Marianne Faithfull's retrospective assessment of the film is symptomatic of the unapologetic-leftist view: "It preserves a whole era under glass [as] an allegory of libertine Chelsea life in the late 60s, with its baronial rock stars, wayward *jeunesse dorée*, drugs, sex, and decadence" (Faithfull, 154). The Thatcherites describe the film the same way, but without Faithfull's nostalgic retrospection: for them it represents where and when Britain went wrong (Savage 1993). And indeed, *Performance* has indelibly marked a retrospective geography of London: today people make the pilgrimage to 81 Powis Square to see where it was filmed, to re-vision their own intimate map of when London was still swinging.

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